Motivation and Emotion

What drives effort, how targets help and hurt, what emotions are made of, and why nobody — including you — can reliably spot a lie from someone's face.

Isagi · November 2026 · Spine: Ciccarelli & White, *Psychology* (4th ed.), Ch. 9 — rewritten, updated and applied

"How do I motivate my team?" is the most common question new managers ask, and the answers they're given are usually Maslow's pyramid and a pep talk. The research offers better tools: a simple formula for when people will try, robust evidence on how to set targets (and how targets backfire), and a clear account of the three needs that keep people engaged without constant bribes. The second half covers emotion — what it is, where it comes from, and how much of it you can read in a face.

Motivation is the process that starts, directs and sustains goal-directed behaviour. **Intrinsic** motivation comes from the activity itself (enjoyment, interest, mastery). **Extrinsic** motivation comes from outside it (pay, prizes, avoiding a reprimand). Most work runs on a mix.

1 The classic theories

- **Instinct theory** — behaviour is driven by inborn, fixed patterns. Early psychologists listed thousands of "instincts", which explained nothing. Abandoned for humans.
- **Drive-reduction theory** (Clark Hull) — a need (food, water) creates a tension, a **drive**, that pushes us to act until the need is met and the body returns to balance (**homeostasis**). Good for hunger and thirst; it can't explain why people seek out challenge, novelty or risk.
- **Arousal theory** — people seek an optimal level of stimulation: too little and we're bored, too much and we're overwhelmed. Some people, high in **sensation seeking**, need more than others.

- **Incentive theory** — behaviour is pulled by external rewards, not just pushed by internal drives. The basis of every incentive scheme (Part 4).

The Yerkes–Dodson law

In 1908 Robert Yerkes and John Dodson found that performance improves with arousal up to a point, then falls. The best level of arousal is lower for complex tasks and higher for simple ones.

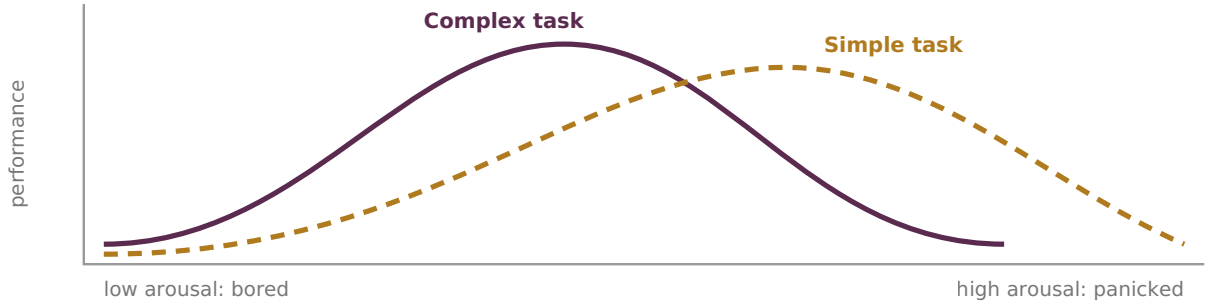


Figure 1. The Yerkes–Dodson curve (schematic). Pressure helps up to a point; complex work peaks at lower pressure than routine work.

The lesson for target-setting: pressure that energises a rep doing routine order-taking can wreck the judgement of a key-account manager negotiating a complex deal. The original study used mice and electric shocks, and the precise inverted U is only loosely supported in humans, but the broad pattern is widely observed.

2 Maslow's hierarchy — and what replaced it

Abraham Maslow (1943) proposed that needs are arranged in a hierarchy: **physiological** (food, sleep), **safety**, **belonging**, **esteem**, and at the top **self-actualisation** — fulfilling one's potential. Lower needs must be largely met before higher ones motivate. (The pyramid drawing came later, from management writers, not from Maslow.)

The categories are useful. The strict order isn't well supported. A 2011 study of over 60,000 people in 123 countries by Louis Tay and Ed Diener found that the needs were indeed universal, but people reported meeting

social and respect needs even when basic needs were unmet, and these contributed to well-being independently. A field rep on a modest salary still cares intensely about recognition and belonging.

Self-determination theory

The best-supported modern theory, from Edward Deci and Richard Ryan, says that people are naturally motivated when three psychological needs are met:

- **Autonomy** — feeling that you choose your actions, not that they're forced on you.
- **Competence** — feeling effective and growing in skill.
- **Relatedness** — feeling connected to others.

Work that meets these needs sustains effort without constant external pressure; work that frustrates them leaves people dependent on carrots and sticks. A manager's practical levers: let reps plan their own beat within clear targets (autonomy), give specific feedback and skill coaching (competence), and build a team that knows each other (relatedness).

McClelland's three needs

David McClelland focused on three learned needs that vary between people: the **need for achievement** (to excel and master challenges), **affiliation** (to be liked and belong) and **power** (to influence others). High achievers like moderately difficult goals and quick feedback, and often make excellent individual salespeople — but not always good managers, because they prefer doing to delegating. McClelland's research suggested that effective managers in large organisations were higher in a socialised need for power — influence used for the organisation — than in achievement or affiliation.

3 Two tools for work motivation

Expectancy theory

Victor Vroom (1964) proposed that people put in effort when three things are true, and that motivation is roughly their product:

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Motivation = Expectancy × Instrumentality × Valence
Expectancy:      "If I try, can I hit the target?"   (0–1)
Instrumentality: "If I hit it, will I get the reward?" (0–1)
Valence:         "Do I value that reward?"           (0–1)
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Because the terms multiply, if any one is near zero, motivation collapses — however large the others are.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1 · THE IMPOSSIBLE TARGET

A rep values the festive-season bonus highly (valence 0.9). The company has always paid it when earned (instrumentality 0.9). Last year's target was a stretch; he rated his chances at 0.6. This year the target is raised 40%; he now rates his chances at 0.15.

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Last year:  0.6  × 0.9 × 0.9 = 0.49
This year:  0.15 × 0.9 × 0.9 = 0.12

Motivation falls by about three-quarters,
with the same bonus on offer.
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Raising the bonus won't fix it: even with valence at 1.0, 0.15 × 0.9 × 1.0 ≈ 0.14. The broken term is expectancy. Fix that — a reachable target, more support, or a stepped bonus that pays partially — and motivation returns. The same logic shows why delayed or disputed bonus payouts are so damaging: they cut instrumentality for every future scheme.

Goal-setting theory

Edwin Locke and Gary Latham's decades of research produced one of the most robust findings in work psychology: **specific, difficult goals** lead to higher performance than easy goals or "do your best" — provided people are committed to the goal, have the ability, and get feedback on progress. The effect is large and holds across many jobs and countries.

It comes with a warning. A 2009 paper called "Goals Gone Wild" documented the side effects of narrow, high-pressure targets: people neglect everything not measured, take excessive risks and are more

likely to cheat. The best-known case is Wells Fargo, where aggressive cross-selling targets led employees to open millions of accounts customers hadn't asked for, exposed in 2016. In channel sales, the same pressure produces stock loading, fake billing and promised discounts the company never approved. Use specific, difficult goals — and watch the behaviour that produces the number, not only the number.

4 Biological motives, briefly

Hunger shows how biology and environment combine. The hypothalamus (Part 1) and hormones signal hunger and fullness, but external cues — the time on the clock, the smell of food, portion size, eating with others — strongly influence when and how much people eat. The same pattern runs through most motives: a biological base, heavily shaped by habit and context.

5 What an emotion is

An **emotion** has three parts: **physiological arousal** (heart rate, breathing, hormones), **behavioural expression** (face, voice, posture) and **subjective experience** (how it feels). The main theories disagree about the order:

Theory	Sequence	In one line
James–Lange (1880s)	Event → body reacts → you feel the emotion	"We feel afraid because we tremble."
Cannon–Bard (1920s)	Event → body reaction and feeling at the same time	Different emotions share similar arousal, so arousal can't be the cause.
Schachter–Singer (1962)	Event → arousal → you look for a label → emotion	Emotion = arousal + interpretation.
Lazarus (cognitive-mediational)	Event → appraisal of what it means for you → emotion and arousal	How you interpret the event comes first.

The two-factor and appraisal views have the most practical use. In a 1974 study, men who met an attractive researcher on a high, swaying suspension bridge rated her as more attractive and were more likely to call her later than men who met her on a low, stable bridge — consistent with arousal from the bridge being relabelled as attraction. Arousal is easily misattributed. A manager walking into a review straight from a stressful call may read irritation into a rep's neutral comment. And because appraisal shapes emotion, the same event — a lost dealer — can produce despair or determination depending on how it's framed.

6 Reading emotions in faces

Paul Ekman's research from the 1960s found that six basic emotions — happiness, sadness, anger, fear, surprise and disgust — were recognised from facial expressions across many cultures, including isolated groups in Papua New Guinea. Later work complicated this. Recognition across cultures is well above chance but lower than within a culture, and some researchers, notably Lisa Feldman Barrett, argue that emotions are constructed by each brain from context rather than triggered as fixed universal programmes. Cultures also have different **display rules** — norms about which emotions to show, when and to whom. A dealer's polite smile in a hierarchical setting may tell you nothing about his satisfaction.

Two popular extensions fare poorly. The **facial-feedback hypothesis** says that making a facial expression intensifies the feeling. A famous 1988 study had people hold a pen in their teeth (forcing a smile) and found they rated cartoons funnier. A 2016 replication across 17 labs found no effect. A larger 2022 project found a small effect for deliberate smiling but not for the pen method — so the effect, if real, is small. And lie detection from faces and body language is close to useless: across hundreds of studies, people judge truth from lies correctly about 54% of the time, barely above the 50% you'd get by guessing. Trained police officers do little better, though they are more confident.

WORKED EXAMPLE 2 · "I CAN ALWAYS TELL WHEN A DEALER IS LYING"

A manager judges 100 claims from dealers, 50 true and 50 false, with the typical 54% accuracy.

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Correct judgements:  54 of 100
By pure guessing:    50 of 100
Gain over guessing:   4 judgements in 100
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Four extra correct calls in a hundred — and he will be confidently wrong in 46. Body language is not evidence. Check claims against records: invoices, stock counts, payment history.

7 Emotions at work

Sales and service jobs require **emotional labour** (Arlie Hochschild, 1983): managing your emotional display as part of the job — staying cheerful with an abusive customer. **Surface acting**, faking an emotion you don't feel, is consistently linked to exhaustion and burnout. **Deep acting**, trying to actually feel the required emotion, for example by seeing the situation from the customer's side, is less draining. Emotions also spread: **emotional contagion** means a manager's visible anxiety before a review travels through the whole team.

8 Held up?

Claim	Verdict	Why
Specific, difficult goals raise performance	**Robust**	Hundreds of studies — with known side effects when goals are narrow and extreme.
Autonomy, competence and relatedness sustain motivation	**Well supported**	Consistent across work, education and health studies in many cultures.
Needs are met in Maslow's strict order	**Not supported**	Needs are universal, but higher needs matter even when lower ones are unmet.
Smiling makes you happier (facial feedback)	**Small at most**	The pen study failed a 17-lab replication; a later project found a small effect for deliberate smiling.
You can spot liars from body language or "microexpressions"	**No**	Average accuracy is about 54%, barely above chance.
Six basic emotions are universally recognised	**Partly**	Recognised above chance across cultures, but less accurately, and with real cultural differences.

Summary

- **Motivation** starts, directs and sustains behaviour; intrinsic and extrinsic sources usually mix.
- Drive-reduction explains biological needs; **arousal** theory explains seeking challenge. **Yerkes–Dodson**: performance peaks at moderate arousal, lower for complex tasks.
- **Maslow's** needs are universal but not strictly ordered. **Self-determination theory**: autonomy, competence and relatedness sustain motivation. McClelland: achievement, affiliation and power vary between people.
- **Expectancy theory**: motivation = expectancy × instrumentality × valence. An impossible target zeroes it, whatever the bonus.
- **Goal-setting**: specific, difficult goals with commitment and feedback work — but narrow, extreme targets breed corner-cutting and cheating.
- Emotion = arousal + expression + experience. Theories differ on order; arousal is easily mislabelled and appraisal shapes the feeling.
- Basic emotions are recognised across cultures above chance, shaped by display rules. Facial feedback is small at most; lie detection from faces is barely above chance.
- **Emotional labour**: faking feelings (surface acting) drives burnout; emotions spread through teams.

Practice problems

P1. A rep rates expectancy 0.8, instrumentality 0.3 (bonuses are often disputed) and valence 0.9. Compute motivation. Which term would you fix first, and how?

P2. Classify each by self-determination need: (a) letting reps choose their own visit sequence; (b) a monthly team lunch; (c) a skills workshop on negotiation with individual feedback.

P3. A new target is "Increase secondary sales by 25% this quarter, no excuses." What risks does goal-setting research predict? Suggest two safeguards.

P4. Using Yerkes–Dodson, explain why the same pre-review pressure might help a rep doing routine order collection but hurt a manager negotiating a complex institutional deal.

P5. A trainer offers a course on "reading microexpressions to detect lying dealers". What does the evidence say, and what would you do instead?

P6. Your customer-care staff are told to "always smile, whatever the customer says". Which kind of emotional labour does this encourage, and what is the risk? Suggest an alternative.

Glossary

Intrinsic / extrinsic motivation

Driven by the activity itself / by outside rewards or pressures.

Drive / homeostasis

Tension from an unmet need / the body's balanced state.

Yerkes–Dodson law

Performance peaks at a moderate level of arousal.

Self-actualisation

Maslow's top need: fulfilling one's potential.

Self-determination theory

Motivation is sustained by autonomy, competence and relatedness.

Need for achievement

A drive to excel and master challenges.

Expectancy theory

Motivation = expectancy × instrumentality × valence.

Goal-setting theory

Specific, difficult goals with feedback raise performance.

Two-factor theory

Emotion = physiological arousal plus a cognitive label.

Appraisal

Interpreting what an event means for you.

Display rules

Cultural norms for showing emotion.

Facial-feedback hypothesis

The idea that facial expressions intensify felt emotion.

Emotional labour

Managing emotional display as part of a job.

Surface / deep acting

Faking an emotion / trying to genuinely feel it.

Emotional contagion
Emotions spreading from person to person.

Answer key

P1. 0.8 × 0.3 × 0.9 = 0.22. Fix instrumentality: publish clear, unambiguous bonus rules, pay on time, and resolve disputes quickly and visibly.

P2. (a) autonomy; (b) relatedness; (c) competence.

P3. Narrow focus on the number, neglect of collections and dealer health, stock loading, unauthorised discounts, possibly fake billing. Safeguards: pair the volume target with quality measures (overdue days, returns, dealer count); audit unusual month-end spikes; make clear that how the number was achieved is reviewed.

P4. Arousal energises simple, practised tasks, but complex tasks peak at lower arousal. High pressure narrows attention and impairs the flexible judgement a complex negotiation needs.

P5. Lie detection from faces and body language averages about 54%, near chance; training adds confidence more than accuracy. Instead, verify claims against records and design processes that don't depend on trust alone.

P6. Surface acting, which is linked to exhaustion and burnout. Alternatives: train deep acting (perspective-taking), give staff authority to resolve problems, allow short recovery breaks after difficult calls, and back staff when customers are abusive.

Sources: chapter structure follows Ciccarelli & White, *Psychology*, 4th ed. (Pearson), Ch. 9; text and figures are original. Tay & Diener, *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 2011. Deci & Ryan, self-determination theory. Vroom, *Work and Motivation*, 1964. Locke & Latham, *American Psychologist*, 2002. Ordóñez et al., "Goals Gone Wild", *Academy of Management Perspectives*, 2009. Dutton & Aron, 1974. Facial feedback: Wagenmakers et al., 2016; Coles et al., *Nature Human Behaviour*, 2022. Lie detection: Bond & DePaulo, *Personality and Social Psychology Review*, 2006. Hochschild, *The Managed Heart*, 1983. Worked-example figures are illustrative.